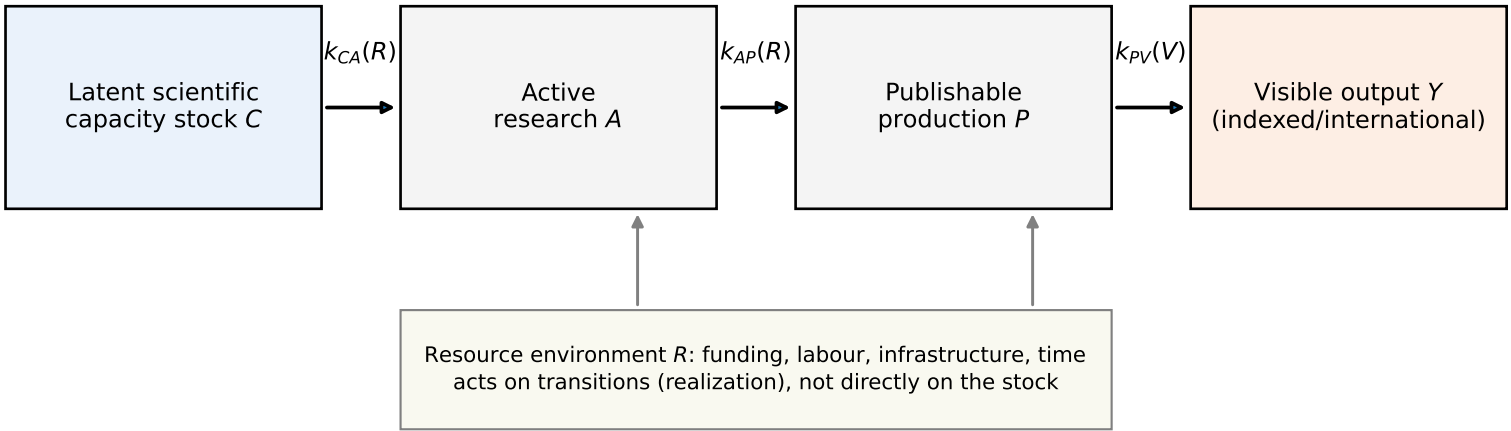Observed bibliometric output Y is a downstream emission of a multi-stage system; a fall in Y does not uniquely identify a fall in C.